that make for engrossing reading as individual chapters, yet are bound together by a sinew of connection as they are anchored in the urgent realities of the Anthropocene. While his science is solid, there is no detachment in expression as he mines his memories evocatively—the liquid eye of a captive blackbuck, meeting the stare of a goral while hiking in the hills around Landour, and his tongue-tied excitement at crossing paths with the ornithologist Sálim Ali in an antique elevator at the Royal Bombay Yacht Club.

Alter juxtaposes past and present as he pays tribute to the natural history illuminati, doffing a hat to Edward Hamilton Aitken's light-hearted but penetrative observations of Indian fauna in *The Tribes on My Frontier*, and Peter Matthiessen's quest for the mysterious and the unseen in *The Snow Leopard*.

Beyond the cacophony of the media's fascination with imported cheetahs from Namibia, *The Cobra's Gaze* invites us to look deeper into the tapestry of India's wildlife and conservation efforts, crystallising the conflicts playing out among these forces. As India's wild places suffer the brunt of rapid urbanisation and explosive population growth, Alter reminds us of the imminent loss through conversations with a few concerned Indians who are fighting the good fight. Illustrated with colour plates, this beautifully produced hardcover book is for every nature-lover's bookshelf. ■

–Bijoy Venugopal

asm clearly captivated Zai Whitaker, whose essay is shot through with affection for a young woman who was a close friend.

The book is full of thrilling discoveries. We go in quest of cave-dwelling Indian swiftlets in the Western Ghats, have a close shave with a Himalayan black bear in Sikkim, watch wild elephants at Periyar Lake, go fishing in Odisha. For me, the standout section is Neha Sinha's portrait of Ghazala Shahabuddin and the oak forests of Uttarakhand. The writing is luminous and precise, full of empathy and an aliveness to the symbiosis between the human and the natural world. Their insights (both writer and subject) about the importance of complexity in ecosystem restoration as much as in society as a whole are worth listening to. We are three years into the UN's designated Decade of Ecosystem Restoration, and books like Anita Mani's could not be more timely or urgent. ■

–Anita Roy

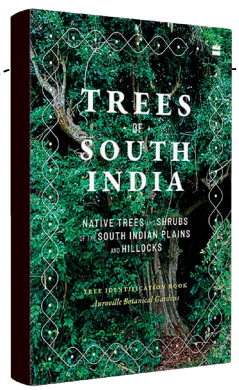
BOOKS

GREEN THUMBS

Compiled by researchers from the Auroville Botanical Gardens, *Trees of South India* catalogues the remarkable flora of the Eastern Ghats

It's only April, and it has already been a bad year for tree-lovers, especially with the news that 6,000 trees were felled in the Jim Corbett National Park to facilitate eco-tourism, that greatest of all environmental fictions. But a dot of light has emerged—a new field guide titled *Trees of South India: Native Trees and Shrubs of the South Indian Plains and Hillocks*, written and compiled by researchers from the Auroville Botanical Gardens. The heavy subtitle hints at the thorough legwork that went into this book, and indeed all the work that went into the reforestation of the region in which Auroville is located. Anyone who has visited Pondicherry in the 1970s will recall vistas of near-dead scrubland that seemed irremediable. Now, it is a multi-layered forest that offers hope that we can rejuvenate our natural wealth.

Pradip Krishen's foreword talks of the value of such field guides in fighting institutions that are expected to preserve our environment but are instead hand in glove with commercial interests.



TREES OF SOUTH INDIA
by Paul Blanchflower and Marie Demont
HARPERCOLLINS
₹799; 248 pages

Paul Blanchflower, in an author's note, describes his own discovery of the forestry movement in and around Auroville. The introduction describes in depth the eastern mass of the southern Indian peninsula, encompassing the Coromandel Coast, the Eastern Ghats and the lower slopes of the Western Ghats. It is for the most part a dry tropical environment with sparse rainfall and large rain shadows. To restore green cover in such an environment is a challenge, since each tree and shrub must be protected much longer than in a wetter climate. But the plant materials with which people would embark on such a project are robust and more widely available than we might fear. With all the industrial and urban activity of the region, there are pockets in which native vegetation thrives—in sacred groves, hill shrines, older national parks, urban parks and the campuses of universities and government institutions.

The 200 pages on tree and shrub species are richly illustrated, with sharp, well-lit colour photographs of leaf, flower, seed, bark and the whole tree, so that the reader can distinguish even similar-looking species. The text description includes the usual habitat of the tree, its uses and the best way to propagate it. Common names in English, Tamil and Hindi are given in addition to the binomial, and an index attached.

As Blanchflower writes in the author's note, there are digitised resources that document the range of flora and fauna in this region. Still, whether you're re-greening a bit of land or exploring the trees around you, a book in hand inspires in its own way. ■

–Latha Anantharaman